sunny day and the open window of our classroom allowed the fresh air to come inside. Despite the moderate temperature, I began to sweat at the teacher's surprise announcement. As she scribbled something with white chalk on a green board hung on the front wall, I put my mind to task, trying to find a valid-sounding excuse. Even though Ms Meenakshi was mostly polite, I knew it would make her angry to see an entirely empty notebook.

'My . . . my dog tore a few pages out,' I mumbled nervously when she finally reached my desk, but then I gathered confidence and continued, 'I've given it to a stationery shop for rebinding. I promise, Ma'am.' For a while she stared at me, and then said, 'All right, Gunjan, show it to me this Monday. There's still a weekend left. I hope you get your notebook back by then'. As she moved on, my friend sitting behind me, who knew I was bluffing, tugged at my skirt. I turned to high-five her. The day's trouble was over.

Everything was forgotten by the evening. Maa, Dada and I went to the officers' mess ante room, where the other families had gathered too. Papaji was out on a military exercise that would go on for a few weeks. Maa would take us to the ante room quite often so we wouldn't miss Papaji. We spent most of our evenings watching the common television in the ante room of the mess, along with other kids and grown-ups.

Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi, one of the most iconic sitcoms of all time, had become popular in India then, particularly in our cantonment. Nobody liked to miss out on the episodes, which would air on Friday nights. It was my favourite television series, and I would give up anything to watch it. But that particular Friday was full of surprises.

That evening, as we entered the mess, I saw that Ms Meenakshi was also present. She had come to spend the weekend at her colleague's place inside the cantonment. My very first glance at her reminded me of the lie I'd dished out to her in the morning about my social science homework. Dinner was served early, since the show started late in the evening. What happened at dinner wasn't in my best interests that evening. Ms Meenakshi pulled up a chair next to Maa's seat. When I arrived with my plate to take my seat in